

Private wells aren't regulated under the Safe Drinking Water Act and aren't tested by any utility — testing is entirely up to the well owner. This schedule follows the testing frequency recommended by the EPA and CDC for private well owners. Keep it with your water system records.

ANNUAL & PERIODIC TESTING

TEST	FREQUENCY	WHY
Total coliform bacteria	EVERY YEAR	The EPA and CDC recommend testing private wells annually for total coliform bacteria. Coliform presence indicates the well may be vulnerable to contamination from surface water, septic systems, or animal waste.
Nitrates	EVERY YEAR	Also recommended annually alongside coliform. Nitrates are especially important to monitor in agricultural areas and homes with infants, since elevated nitrate levels are linked to methemoglobinemia ("blue baby syndrome") in infants under six months.
pH	EVERY YEAR	Water that is too acidic or too alkaline can corrode plumbing and fixtures, and can affect how metals like lead leach from pipes.
Total dissolved solids (TDS)	EVERY YEAR	A general indicator of overall mineral content. Rising TDS over time can signal a change in your water source worth investigating further.
Arsenic	EVERY 3–5 YRS	Naturally occurring in some bedrock and groundwater. Ask your county or state health department whether arsenic is common in your area — many maintain regional groundwater data.
Lead	EVERY 3–5 YRS	Usually comes from household plumbing or fixtures rather than the well itself, particularly in older homes. Ask your county health department about testing options and local plumbing-age guidance.
Radon	EVERY 3–5 YRS	Relevant mainly in certain regions and geologic formations. Ask your county health department whether radon testing is recommended in your area.

TEST IMMEDIATELY IF...

- Your well area has flooded or standing water reached the wellhead
- You notice a change in taste, odor, or color
- There is a new infant, or someone is pregnant, in the home
- Land use has changed nearby (new farming, industry, construction, or a new septic system)
- Any well work, repair, or pump replacement was recently done
- A neighboring well has tested positive for a contaminant

READING YOUR REPORT

MCL stands for **Maximum Contaminant Level** — the legal limit the EPA sets for that substance in public drinking water. Private wells aren't required to meet it, but MCLs are the standard reference point labs use to flag a result as high. A result "above the MCL" for a contaminant means it exceeds the level the EPA considers safe for regular consumption; a result "below the MCL" or "non-detect" means the substance was not found, or was found under that limit. If any result is unclear or elevated, contact your lab or county health department before making treatment decisions.

RESULTS LOG

DATE	TEST	RESULT	ACTION TAKEN

DATE	TEST	RESULT	ACTION TAKEN